DESIGN BY «HISTORY OF THE BOAT» FOR STAMPS BY COPREFIL

Anton Yu. Andreev[1], Moscow
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Abstract: we investigate the issue of non-postage stamps presumably printed by COPREFIL during Special Period of 1991-2000 in Cuba. As an additional argument, we consider the common design of stamps under the name of Afghanistan, Benin, Cambodia (Kampuchea), Guinea-Bissau, Sahrawi Republic (The SADR).

Keywords: philately, postage stamps, Cinderella stamps, Cuba, Empresa de COPREFIL, 1991, Special Period, history of the boat, Dyghalo, Narbekov.

[1] PhD, independent researcher in numismatics. E-mail: antand@mail.ru.

National Office of Post, Press and Philately (Empresa de Correos, Prensa y Filatelia; Empresa de COPREFIL, in Spanish) was created in Cuba within Ministry of Communications. COPREFIL was responsible for the organization of production, marketing, export of Cuban postage stamps and FDC. In the 1980s, this company executed official orders for printing postage stamps on behalf of other countries, including Afghanistan, Vietnam, Guinea-Bissau, Cambodia (Kampuchea)[2], Congo, Laos, Nicaragua, Peru[3] (Fig. 1.1).



Fig. 1.1. Examples of postage stamps 1989 printed by COPREFIL
(Kampuchea Mi#KH1012, Nicaragua Mi#NI2925, Peru Mi#PE1419)

We assume that during 1991-2000 COPREFIL participated in large-scale production of Cinderella stamps[4] and FDC under the name of certain states such as Afghanistan, Benin, Cambodia, Guinea, Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic (The SADR). All of these countries historically had close relations with Cuba, as well as relatively weak political and economic development, which would make it difficult to counter third-party commercial sales of non-postage stamps.

Postal Administration of Afghanistan does not recognize stamps, issued under the name of Afghanistan during 1990-2000, as legal postage stamps[5].

Official nature of numerous series of stamps under the name of Cambodia during 1990-2001 is questionable (Bailey 2018), although at least some stamps of 1998-2000 series participated in postal circulation until mid-2013.

Issues under the name of The SADR first appeared in May 1990 and were printed until 2001 (Dietz 2017). In total, more than 630 types of such cinderellas have been produced. Official nature of these issues has not been confirmed[6]. Sahrawi Republic is a partially recognized state, it is not a member of the Universal Postal Union (UPU), and does not have a national postal service. Moreover, UPU has repeatedly issued circulars with official position of Moroccan postal administration on illegal nature of cinderellas under the name of The SADR.

[2] Since 1983 to 2001-02, when Cambodian authorities changed service provider for stamps design and printing, choosing Postal Stamps Printing Company (Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam) (Bailey 2018).
[3] See research by Roque Castillo «Butterflies of Peru 1990» (Castillo 2020).
[4] Cinderellas or non-postage stamps, small-format pieces made by graphic methods on paper with no relation to postal circulation.
[5] See UPU circular № 345 dated 21.08.2000. At the same time, at least part of these issues could have been «sanctioned» by the Government of the Northern Alliance of Ahmad Shah Massoud and Burhanudin Rabbani 1992-96, under presumably existed contract with Global Philatelie GmbH (Germany) (Jack 2013).
[6] See John Lowe's research upon illegal stamps of Morocco under the name of Sahrawi Republic (Lowe 2021).

At least 8 series of 1980-2000 period postage stamps and cinderellas, presumably printed by COPREFIL, are linked by a single plot (Table 1.1).

№	State	Year	Series type	Series name
1	Cuba	1985	postage stamps	«World Philatelic Exhibition»
2	Afghanistan	1986	postage stamps	«Ancient sailboats»
3	Kampuchea	1986	postage stamps	«Ancient sailboats»
4	Guinea-Bissau	1988	postage stamps	«Ancient sailboats»
5	Afghanistan	1997	cinderellas	«Ancient sailboats»
6	Benin	1997	cinderellas	«Ancient sailboats»
7	Sahrawi Republic	1998	cinderellas	«Ancient vessels»
8	Afghanistan	1999	cinderellas	«Vessels»

Table 1.1. Certain series of postage stamps and cinderellas 1980-2000

Their design features remarkable illustrations by Soviet rear admiral, marine writer, professor of the Academy of Military Sciences Viktor Dyghalo (*1926-†2011), and Soviet artist Nikolai Narbekov (†1981) from a set of 32 art postcards «History of the boat» (issue 1). Its first edition was printed in Moscow in 1981. In turn, these authors used numerous archival materials, works by Russian, Soviet, and foreign authors who were specialists in the history of world shipbuilding (Dyghalo 1981).

From 1962 to 1993, so-called Group of Soviet (Russian) military specialists was stationed in Cuba, thus it is not a surprise that COPREFIL designers could obtain such a set of art postcards.

We assume that these illustrations were used in design of stamps without approval from «Izobrazitel'noe iskusstvo» Soviet publishing house.

In Table 1.2, for each of the series listed in Table 1.1, we provide detailed information with face values of postage stamps, cinderellas, and index numbers of art postcards that were used in design of these items. Curiously, 11 of 32 art postcards remained «unused», and some were «used» 2-3 times.

Appendix contains 7 examples with illustrations by Dyghalo-Narbekov in comparison to images of stamps and cinderellas, later printed in Cuba by COPREFIL.

For more information see:
Andreev Anton. «HISTORY OF THE BOAT» AND COPREFIL // 2025.
https://www.academia.edu/126729471 (date of access – 01.01.2025)

#	Postcard name / series notional number from Table 1.1	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	Egyptian merchant ship		7 & 50		5		135		
2	Seaworthy merchant ship of Egypt		9			4 000			
3	Egyptian warship			1	200				150 000
4	Ship of the Aegean Sea (island of Crete)								
5	Phoenician merchant ship				50				10 000
6	Phoenician warship								
7	Assyro-Phoenician merchant ship		5				200		
8	Assyro-Phoenician warship								
9	Greek bireme				500				20 000
10	Greek merchant ship						150		
11	Roman bireme								
12	Roman trireme (trier)								
13	Roman merchant ship	1					270	200	
14	Roman pentera (pentecotera)								
15	Roman galley								
16	Etruscan vessel								
17	Gokstad ship (drakar)								
18	Norman schnacker		4						40 000
19	Norman knorr						300		
20	William the Conqueror's Ship								
21	Russian fighting boat			1,5		1 200			
22	Northern European dromon		11			600			
23	Genoese merchant ship					1 500			
24	English merchant ship			0,2			1 000		
25	Richard III's Ship		6						600 00
26	Hanseatic cog			0,5		400			
27	Danish warship								50 000
28	French merchant ship			3					
29	Ancient Chinese junk								
30	Mediterranean vessel			0,8			400		
31	Venetian cargo ship			2		800			
32	Merchant ship of Northern Europe		8			1 000			
33	Greek bireme (on the cover)				300				30 000

Table 1.2. Art postcards «History of the boat» 1981 series, postage stamps and cinderellas 1980-2000

References

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4. Dyghalo V.A. Istoriya korablya [History of the boat]. Issue 1 / Moscow, Izobrazitel'noe iskusstvo [Fine arts], 1981. (in Russian)
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Appendix. «History of the boat» in design of stamps by COPREFIL

In parentheses we show the numbers of stamps by MICHEL stamps catalog.



Fig. 2.1. Postcard №1 «Egyptian merchant ship» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)





Fig. 2.2. «Ancient sailboats» 1986 series of block and postage stamp of Afghanistan (Mi#AF1523, Mi#AF-BL82)



Fig. 2.3. «Egyptian merchant ship» 1988 postage stamp of Guinea-Bissau (Mi#GW967)



Fig. 2.4. «Egyptian merchant ship» 1997 cinderella of Benin (Mi#BJ971)

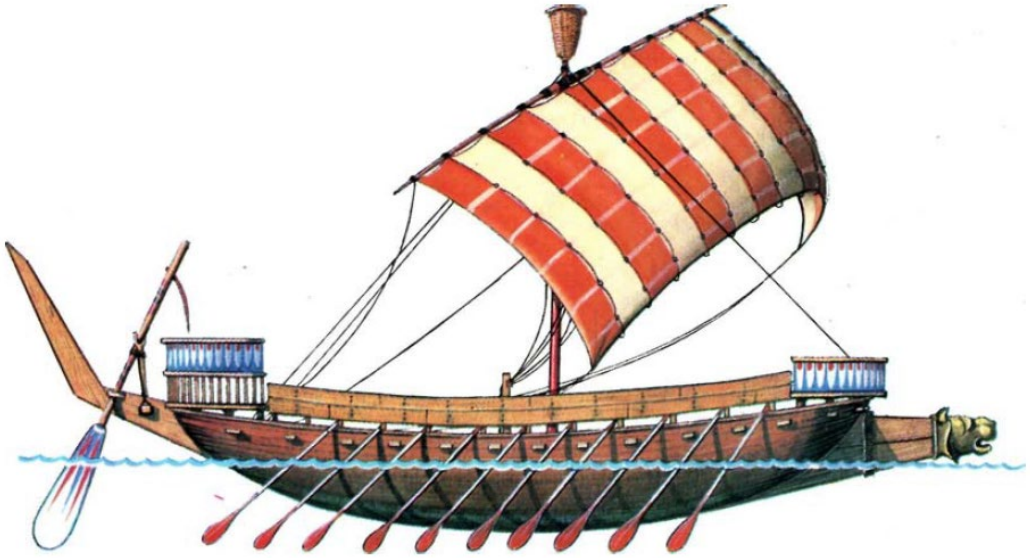


Fig. 3.1. Postcard №3 «Egyptian warship» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 3.2. «Ancient sailboats» 1986 postage stamp of Kampuchea (Mi#KH779)



Fig. 3.3. «Ship of Pharaoh Ramses III» 1988 postage stamp of Guinea-Bissau (Mi#GW970)



Fig. 3.4. «Egyptian warship» 1999 cinderella of Afghanistan (Mi#AF1936)

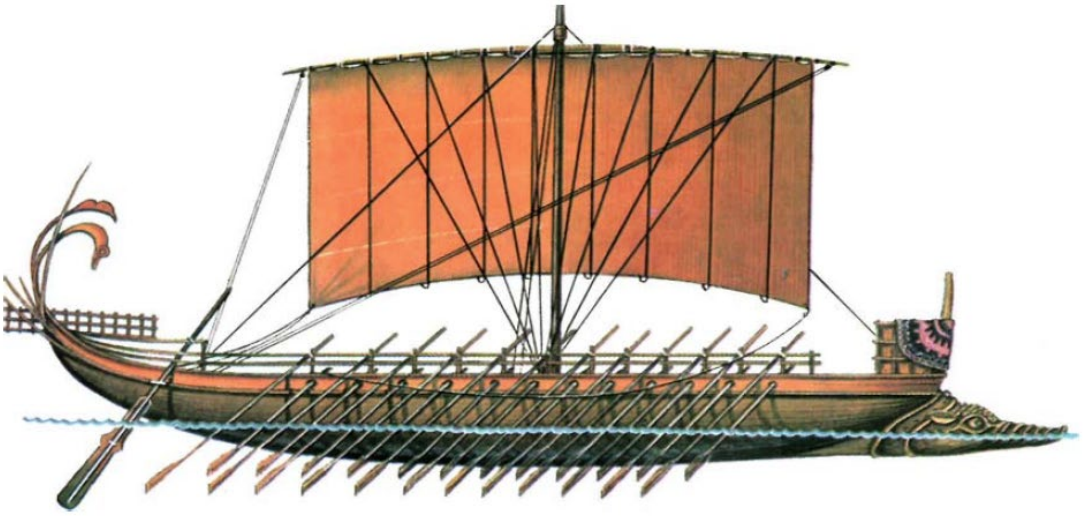


Fig. 4.1. Postcard №9 «Greek bireme» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 4.2. «Etruscan bireme» postage stamp of Guinea-Bissau (June 1988) (Mi#GW972)



Fig. 4.3. «Grecian bireme» cinderella of Afghanistan (December 1999) (Mi#AF1931)

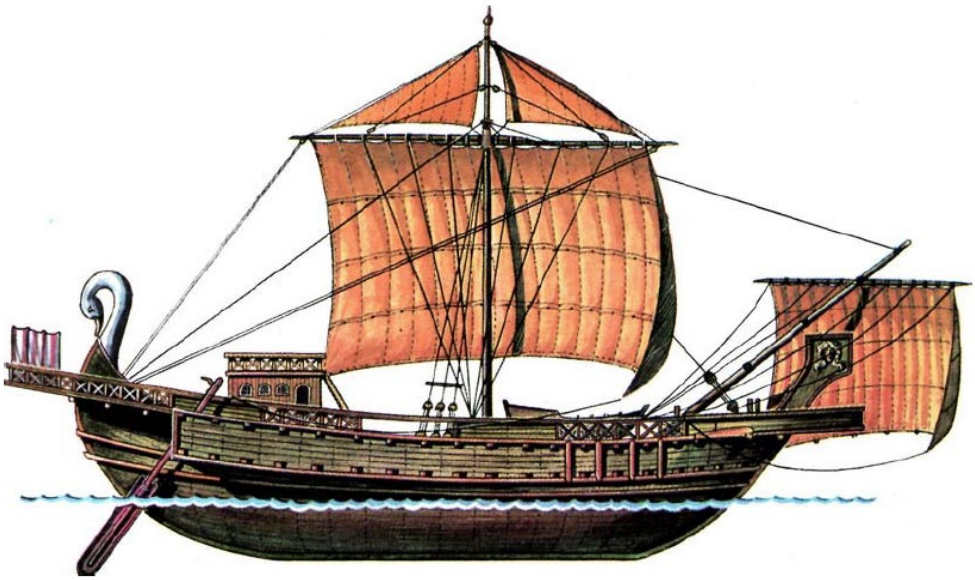


Fig. 5.1. Postcard №13 «Roman merchant ship» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 5.2. «World Philatelic Exhibition. Italy-85» postage block of Cuba (September 1985) (Mi#CU-BL91)



Fig. 5.3. «Roman merchant ship» 2007 postage stamp of Georgia (Mi#GE533)[7]



Fig. 5.4. «Roman merchant ship» 1997 cinderella of Benin (Mi#BJ974)



Fig. 5.5. «Roman merchant ship» 1998 cinderella of Sahrawi Republic

[7] Post of Georgia indicates an author of this series as B. Gagnidze. Series was printed by Alex Matsoukis SA (Greece).



Fig. 6.1. Postcard №21 «Russian fighting boat» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 6.2. «Russian fighting boat» 1986 postage stamp of Kampuchea (Mi#KH780)



Fig. 6.3. «Russian fighting boat» 1997 cinderella of Afghanistan (Mi#AF1744)



Fig. 7.1. Postcard №22 «Northern European dromon» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 7.2. «International Stamp Exhibition in Stockholm» postage stamp of Afghanistan (August 1986) (Mi#AF1526)



Fig. 7.3. «Northern European dromon» 1997 cinderella of Afghanistan (Mi#AF1741)

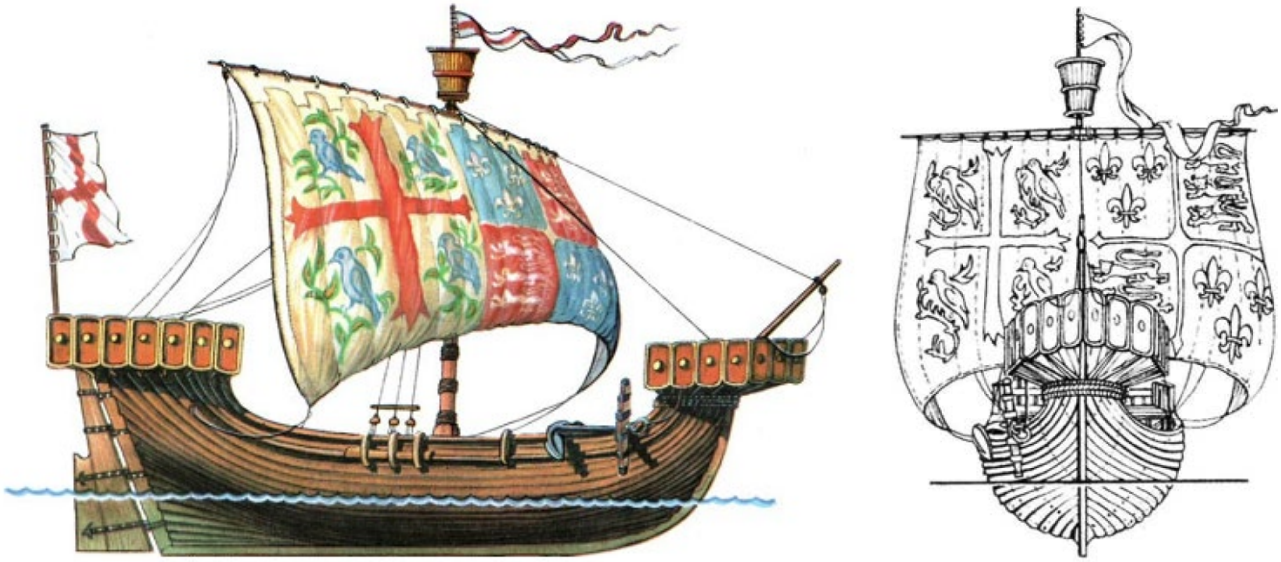


Fig. 8.1. Postcard №24 «English merchant ship» (Dyghalo, Narbekov, 1981)



Fig. 8.2. Seal of Supreme Admiral of England, Earl of Rutland, Edward of Norwich, 2nd Duke of York, 1395 (National Maritime Museum, Great Britain)



Fig. 8.3. Engraving with the seal of Supreme Admiral of England, Edward of Norwich, Earl of Rutland, 1395 (Firmin-Didot, 1888)

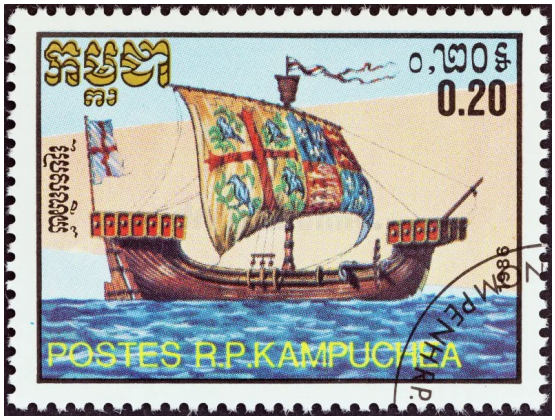


Fig. 8.4. «English merchant ship» 1986 postage stamp of Kampuchea (Mi#KH776)

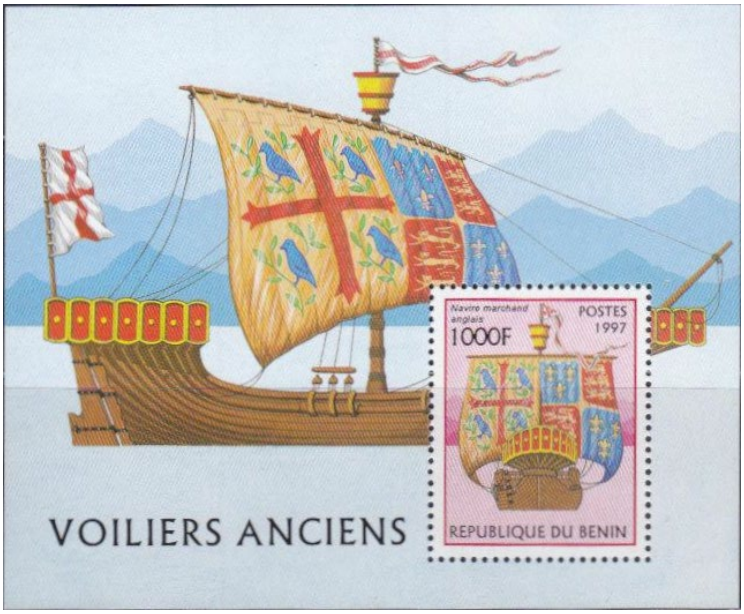


Fig. 8.5. «English merchant ship» cinderella of Benin (August 1997) (Mi#BJ977)

Kampuchea coins and stamps could be purchased with FDC 1986 (Fig. 8.6).



Fig. 8.6. «Ancient sailboat» 1986 FDC with postage stamp (Mi#KH776) and coin 1988 (KM#71) of Kampuchea